HEMANT SOREN 49
Chief Minister, Jharkhand
KALPANA SOREN 39
MLA and Hemant's wife

IT TAKES TWO TO TANGO

Hemant and Kalpana Soren changed Jharkhand's political game, converting near-collapse into an extraordinary comeback

By Amitabh Srivastava

The year 2024 unfolded in Jharkhand like a bit of an earthquake. At the epicentre of this seismic event stood a couple, chief minister Hemant Soren and his wife Kalpana. Their remarkable comeback after weathering intense storms made for political theatre compelling enough to enter tribal folklore, and then spill over to the national narrative. The drama had its genesis on January 31, when Hemant tendered his resignation from the CM's post—he was to be arrested by the Enforcement Directorate, after hours of interrogation at his official residence on money-laundering allegations.

For many, that would have signalled the end of a political career. For Hemant and his wife Kalpana, it marked the beginning of an extraordinary saga. Faced with a leadership vacuum and the shadows of impending oblivion, the couple undertook an odyssey of grit, strategy and reinvention that culminated in an emphatic electoral victory in November.

One question hung in the air after that grim prologue: who to anoint in his place? His father, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) patriarch Shibu Soren, was beset by deteriorating health. Hemant reluctantly handed over the chief ministerial reins to Champai Soren, a trusted if uninspiring lieutenant. Such was the despondency that Hemant's sister-in-law, Sita Soren, deserted the party in March to join its chief rival, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). It seemed like curtains for the JMM.

Under Champai's lacklustre stewardship, the JMM faltered. Languishing in judicial custody, Hemant could not campaign for the Lok Sabha polls. The result: the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) captured nine of Jharkhand's 14 seats, leading in 50 of the 81 assembly segments. But even if the JMM appeared to be teetering on the edge of an existential crisis, that dark moment was not without a silver lining. The JMM-Congress alliance won all five constituencies reserved for Scheduled Tribes. Not just that. A whole new lode of silver had been found: Kalpana Soren.

Partners in Victory

- **Hemant's arrest in January and subsequent resignation marked the beginning of an extraordinary political journey for him and his wife, Kalpana**
- **Initially reluctant, Kalpana stepped into the political limelight during Hemant's incarceration, winning the Gandey byelection in June and becoming a formidable political force**
- **Hemant's return in July saw the launch of bold initiatives like the Maiya Samman Yojana, alongside coordinated election campaigns by Kalpana, which revitalised the JMM's appeal**
- **The JMM-led INDIA bloc won 56 seats in the November assembly polls, securing Hemant's record fourth term as CM**
- **On November 23, when Kalpana landed in Ranchi from Giridih, poll results were already clear. Hemant greeted her at the airport with a bouquet, calling her the "star campaigner"**